

Essay Rubric

Score each essay 1–4 on five dimensions (max 20). Share the rubric *before* she writes — a rubric is a target, not a gotcha. **17+ = excellent. 13–16 = solid. Below 13 = one focused revision pass on the weakest dimension**, not a redo of the whole essay.

The five dimensions

1. Evidence (did she actually do the research?)

- **4** — Specific facts, local numbers, named sources woven through; you could check her claims
- **3** — Real research present, but some claims float without sources
- **2** — Mostly general statements that could have been written without doing the research
- **1** — Vibes

2. Position (did she commit to a point of view?)

- **4** — Clear stance, defended; addresses the strongest counterargument honestly
- **3** — Takes a stance but dodges the hard opposing points
- **2** — Fence-sitting; “both have pros and cons” with no verdict
- **1** — No discernible position

3. Honesty (does it engage with the hard parts?)

- **4** — Names real doubts, costs, and risks, and reasons through them; sounds like a person deciding, not a brochure
- **3** — Acknowledges downsides but hand-waves them
- **2** — Tells the reader (you) what they want to hear
- **1** — Pure performance

4. Her own thinking (is anything here *hers*?)

- **4** — Draws her own connections and conclusions; at least one idea that wasn’t in any source
- **3** — Good synthesis of sources but nothing beyond them
- **2** — Assembled summary of what she read
- **1** — Reads like AI or a template filled in

5. Craft (is it readable and finished?)

- **4** — Clear structure, clean sentences, within word count, proofread
- **3** — Readable with rough patches
- **2** — Disorganized or clearly unproofread

- **1** — Fragmentary

Notes for the grader (you)

- **Grade the thinking, not the conclusion.** If she argues well for a path you disagree with, that's a 4 on Position — the program's goal is that she can research and decide, not that she reaches a pre-approved answer. Argue back in the conversation, as an equal, if you disagree.
- **The conversation is half the assessment.** Someone who did the work can go off-script, answer "what surprised you?", and defend choices. Someone who didn't, can't. If the essay is thin but the conversation is rich, the learning happened — say so, and coach the writing separately.
- **Praise Honesty (dimension 3) loudest.** It's the dimension teenagers sandbag first when writing for a parent, and the whole program depends on her telling you what she really thinks.
- **Feedback ratio:** name the two strongest things before the one thing to fix. You want more essays, which means writing them has to feel like winning.